

The Solopreneur Tech Stack

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The Solopreneur Tech Stack Guide: Every Tool You Need at Every Revenue Level

Price: \$17

What this is

A complete tool-by-tool breakdown organized by how much money you're making. Because the tools that make sense at \$0/month are different from what makes sense at \$10K/month.

No affiliate links influencing recommendations. No "best tool ever" hype. Just what works, what it costs, what it replaces, and when to upgrade.

Every tool in this guide has been evaluated on: cost, time saved, revenue impact, and whether a free alternative exists. If there's a free option that's 80% as good, I'll tell you.

How this guide works

There are 4 revenue tiers. Start at your current tier. Only upgrade when you hit the next tier AND a tool is actually bottlenecking you.

Rule: Never spend more than 60% of revenue on tools and team. If you're making \$500/month, your total tool spend should be under \$300/month. The rest is profit (or reinvestment into paid ads and growth).

Tier	Revenue	Total Tool Budget	Focus
0	\$0-500/mo	\$0-150/mo	Launch everything cheap
1	\$500-2K/mo	\$150-400/mo	Upgrade bottlenecks
2	\$2K-10K/mo	\$400-1,500/mo	Scale output + paid acquisition
3	\$10K+/mo	\$1,500-5,000/mo	Production-grade + team

The 12 tool categories

Every solopreneur needs tools in these 12 categories. I'll cover each one across all 4 tiers.

1. AI writing and content
2. AI image generation
3. AI video and UGC
4. AI voice

5. Email marketing and newsletters
 6. Cold outreach
 7. Social media scheduling
 8. Website and hosting
 9. Payments and monetization
 10. Analytics and tracking
 11. Design and graphics
 12. Automation and workflows
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Category 1: AI writing and content

What you need: Draft blog posts, social content, emails, product descriptions, ad copy, and scripts.

Tier 0: \$0/month

ChatGPT (free tier)

- 3.5-level responses, decent for drafts
- Limited to shorter conversations
- Good for: social posts, short emails, product descriptions

Claude.ai (free tier)

- Better at longer content, follows instructions more precisely
- Limited daily messages
- Good for: blog posts, detailed outlines, content strategies

Google Gemini (free)

- Multimodal (text + images)
- Good for brainstorming and research
- Handles large context windows well

Use this combo: Claude for long-form drafts, ChatGPT for quick social posts, Gemini for research with lots of source material.

Tier 1: \$20/month

ChatGPT Plus (\$20/month) OR Claude Pro (\$20/month)

Pick one. Not both.

ChatGPT Plus if: You need image generation (DALL-E built in), you use lots of plugins, or you prefer a conversational style.

Claude Pro if: You write long-form content, you need precise instruction-following, or you work with large documents.

When to upgrade: When free tier limits are costing you more than 30 minutes/day in workarounds.

Tier 2: \$20-120/month

Claude Pro (\$20/month) + ChatGPT Plus (\$20/month)

Now you can afford both. Use each for its strengths.

OR Claude Max (\$100/month) if you're using Claude Code for app building (unlimited Opus).

Add: Jasper (\$49/month) -- Only if you're producing 50+ pieces of content per week and need brand voice consistency. Otherwise unnecessary.

Tier 3: \$100-200/month

Claude Max (\$100/month) for heavy AI usage + coding

ChatGPT Plus (\$20/month) as backup and for DALL-E

API access for automation workflows (pay per use, usually \$10-50/month)

Category 2: AI image generation

What you need: Social media graphics, blog images, product mockups, thumbnails, persona images.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Canva (free tier)

- Templates for everything: social posts, presentations, thumbnails
- Limited but functional AI image generation
- Good enough for 90% of solopreneur visual needs

Ideogram (free tier)

- Best free AI image generator for text-in-images
- 25 free generations/day
- Better than DALL-E for logo-style graphics

Leonardo.ai (free tier)

- 150 tokens/day (roughly 30 images)
- Good quality for social media assets
- Consistent style generation

Tier 1: \$12-13/month

Leonardo.ai Apprentice (\$12/month)

- 8,500 tokens/month
- Better quality models

- Good for: bulk social graphics, persona images, product visuals

OR Canva Pro (\$13/month)

- Background remover, brand kit, premium templates
- AI image generation built in
- Better for: non-technical users who want drag-and-drop

Pick based on your main need: Mostly photo-realistic or artistic images = Leonardo. Mostly templated graphics with text = Canva Pro.

Tier 2: \$29-42/month

Midjourney (\$10/month basic, \$30/month standard)

- Highest quality AI images
- Best for: hero images, thumbnails, marketing visuals
- Requires Discord (slight learning curve)

+ Canva Pro (\$13/month) for post-processing and templates

Tier 3: \$50-100/month

Midjourney Standard (\$30/month) for premium visuals

Leonardo Premium (\$30/month) for bulk generation

Canva Pro (\$13/month) for assembly and templates

Flux/Stable Diffusion (self-hosted, \$0) for unlimited generation if you have a capable GPU

Category 3: AI video and UGC

What you need: Short-form video content (TikTok, Reels, Shorts), UGC ads, talking head videos, product demos.

Tier 0: \$0/month

CapCut (free)

- Full-featured mobile and desktop editor
- Auto-captions, templates, effects
- Exports at 1080p
- This is genuinely all you need to start

Kling AI (free tier)

- 5-second AI video clips
- Good for attention-grabbing hooks
- Limited but useful

Veo 2 via Google AI Studio (free)

- Google's video generation model
- Surprisingly good quality for \$0
- Limited daily generations

Tier 1: \$6-24/month

D-ID Lite (\$6/month) -- AI talking head videos. Upload a photo, add script, get video. Good for UGC-style content without filming yourself.

OR HeyGen (\$24/month) -- Higher quality AI avatars. Better lip sync, more realistic. Worth it if UGC video is a core part of your strategy.

+ Kling AI Pro (\$8/month) -- Better quality, longer clips, more control.

Tier 2: \$48-72/month

HeyGen Business (\$48/month) -- Unlimited videos, custom avatars, API access

Kling AI Pro (\$8/month)

Opus Clip (\$9/month) -- Auto-clips from long-form video. Upload a 20-minute video, get 10 short clips optimized for each platform.

Tier 3: \$100-200/month

Full video production stack:

- HeyGen Business (\$48/month) for UGC
- Runway (\$12/month) for cinematic AI video
- CapCut Pro (\$20/month) for editing
- Descript (\$24/month) for text-based editing
- Opus Clip (\$19/month) for auto-clipping

Category 4: AI voice

What you need: Voiceovers for videos, podcasts, courses, automated phone calls.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Your own voice + phone recorder

- Seriously. Record yourself talking. It's free and authentic.
- Clean up audio in CapCut (noise removal is built in)

Edge TTS (free)

- Microsoft's text-to-speech API
- Multiple voices and languages

- Quality is decent, not premium

Tier 1: \$5/month

ElevenLabs Starter (\$5/month)

- 30 minutes of audio/month (~6 videos)
- Voice cloning (upload 3 minutes of your voice)
- Natural-sounding output

Tier 2: \$22/month

ElevenLabs Creator (\$22/month)

- 100 minutes/month (~20 videos)
- Professional voice clone
- Multiple voice profiles

Tier 3: \$22-99/month

ElevenLabs Scale (\$99/month) if producing daily content

Fish Audio as alternative for non-English content

GPT-SoVITS (free, self-hosted) if you have the technical ability

Category 5: Email marketing and newsletters

What you need: Subscriber list management, automated sequences, broadcasts, analytics.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Beehiiv (free, up to 2,500 subscribers)

- Best free newsletter platform in 2026
- Built-in referral program
- Monetization features (ads, paid subscriptions)
- Better than Mailchimp free tier

Tier 1: \$0/month (still free)

Stay on Beehiiv free until you hit 2,500 subscribers. No reason to upgrade before that.

Add Substack (free) as a second distribution channel. Cross-post your newsletter to Substack Notes for discovery.

Tier 2: \$42/month

Beehiiv Scale (\$42/month)

- Unlimited subscribers
- Advanced automations
- Custom domains
- A/B testing

Tier 3: \$42-99/month

Beehiiv Scale (\$42/month) or Beehiiv Max (\$99/month)

- Max adds priority support and advanced features
- Only worth it at 25K+ subscribers

ConvertKit (\$29-59/month) as alternative if you need complex automation sequences.

Category 6: Cold outreach

What you need: Find prospects, verify emails, send cold email at scale, track responses.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Manual Gmail outreach

- Create 2-3 Gmail aliases
- Send 10-15 cold emails per day per alias
- Track responses in a spreadsheet
- Free but slow

Apollo.io (free tier)

- 50 email credits/month for lead finding
- Built-in email sending (limited)
- Good starting point for B2B leads

Tier 1: \$37-50/month

Instantly.ai (\$37/month)

- Connect multiple inboxes
- Built-in warmup
- Automated sequences with follow-ups
- The standard tool for cold email in 2026

+ 3 domains (\$36/year total)

- Buy 3 sending domains at \$12/year each
- Never send cold email from your primary domain

Tier 2: \$100-150/month

Instantly.ai (\$37/month) for sending

Apollo.io (\$49/month) for lead data

+ 5-7 inboxes (\$7/month each via Google Workspace)

Tier 3: \$200-400/month

Smartlead (\$39/month) + Clay (\$149/month)

- Smartlead for email infrastructure
- Clay for AI-powered personalization at scale
- Clay enriches leads with custom data points and writes hyper-personalized first lines

Category 7: Social media scheduling

What you need: Schedule posts across multiple platforms, manage content calendar, track basic analytics.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Buffer (free)

- 3 channels, 10 posts per queue
- Covers Twitter + LinkedIn + one more
- Good enough if you're posting manually to others

Manually posting to platforms not covered by Buffer. Use a spreadsheet to track what goes where.

Tier 1: \$9-15/month

Buffer Essentials (\$6/channel/month) for 5+ channels

OR Publer (\$12/month) for unlimited scheduling

Publer is better value at scale. Buffer has a cleaner interface.

Tier 2: \$24-39/month

Publer (\$24/month Professional)

- AI post generation
- Bulk scheduling via CSV
- All major platforms
- Workspace for team

Tier 3: \$39-79/month

Publer Business (\$39/month) or SocialBee (\$79/month)

- Advanced analytics
 - Team collaboration
 - Content categories/recycling
 - White-label reports for clients
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Category 8: Website and hosting

What you need: Landing pages, blog, lead capture, product pages.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Carrd (free tier)

- One-page sites only but that's often enough
- Fast to build, looks professional
- Good for: lead capture, coming soon, simple landing page

Vercel (free tier)

- Deploy Next.js, React, or static sites
- Generous free tier (100GB bandwidth)
- Great for developers and vibe coders

Tier 1: \$9-19/month

Carrd Pro (\$9/year) -- Custom domains, forms, multiple pages

OR Framer (\$5-15/month) -- Visual website builder, beautiful templates

OR Vercel + custom domain (\$10-15/year for domain)

Tier 2: \$20-40/month

Vercel Pro (\$20/month) -- More bandwidth, team features, analytics

+ Supabase (free tier) for database

+ Custom domain (\$15/year)

Tier 3: \$50-100/month

Vercel Pro (\$20/month) + Supabase Pro (\$25/month) + Redis (via Upstash, \$10/month)

- Production-grade infrastructure
 - Handles high traffic
 - Real-time features
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Category 9: Payments and monetization

What you need: Accept payments, sell digital products, manage subscriptions.

Tier 0: \$0/month (pay per transaction)

Stripe -- 2.9% + \$0.30 per transaction

- Industry standard
- Handles subscriptions, one-time, and marketplace payments
- Free to set up

Whop -- For digital products

- Built-in community, courses, and product hosting
- Transaction fee only
- Better discovery than Gumroad

Gumroad -- 10% flat fee per transaction

- Simple setup, good for first digital product
- Higher fee than Stripe direct but easier to use
- Note: Whop takes less per transaction at scale

Tier 1: Same tools, no change needed

Payment processors scale with you. No reason to upgrade until you're doing \$10K+/month.

Tier 2: Same + add

LemonSqueezy as Gumroad alternative -- Lower fees, better checkout

RevenueCat for in-app subscriptions if you have apps

Tier 3: Add specialized tools

Paddle for international tax handling

Chargebee for complex subscription management

Stripe Atlas for incorporating as a US company (if international)

Category 10: Analytics and tracking

What you need: Know what's working, what's not, where your traffic comes from, and what converts.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Google Analytics 4 (free)

- Website traffic, user behavior, conversion tracking
- Required if you have a website
- 10-minute setup

Google Search Console (free)

- SEO performance: keywords, rankings, impressions
- Index your pages properly
- Find content improvement opportunities

Platform native analytics

- Twitter Analytics, YouTube Studio, Instagram Insights
- All free, all useful
- Check weekly

Tier 1: \$0/month (still free)

Free analytics tools are genuinely sufficient for most solopreneurs making under \$2K/month. Don't overcomplicate this.

Add: Hotjar (free tier) -- Heatmaps showing where users click and scroll. Useful for landing page optimization.

Tier 2: \$0-30/month

Plausible (\$9/month) or Fathom (\$14/month) -- Privacy-focused, simpler alternatives to GA4. Cleaner dashboard, faster insights.

Mixpanel (free tier) -- If you have an app and need event tracking.

Tier 3: \$30-100/month

Mixpanel (\$25+/month) -- Product analytics for apps

PostHog (free self-hosted or \$0-450/month cloud) -- Full product analytics suite

Amplitude -- If you need cohort analysis at scale

Category 11: Design and graphics

What you need: Social media templates, presentations, thumbnails, brand assets.

Tier 0: \$0/month

Canva (free tier)

- Covers 90% of design needs
- Templates for everything
- Drag and drop, no design skills needed

Figma (free tier)

- Professional design tool
- Good for app mockups and wireframes
- Steeper learning curve than Canva

Tier 1: \$13/month

Canva Pro (\$13/month)

- Brand kit (save your colors, fonts, logos)
- Background remover
- Premium templates and stock photos
- Magic resize (adapt one design to all platforms)

Tier 2: \$13/month (same)

Canva Pro handles everything. Don't add more design tools unless you're hiring a designer.

Tier 3: \$13-46/month

Canva Pro (\$13/month) + Figma Pro (\$15/month if needed) + Adobe Express (\$18/month only if you need it)

Most solopreneurs never need to leave Canva Pro.

Category 12: Automation and workflows

What you need: Connect tools together, automate repetitive tasks, build workflows without code.

Tier 0: \$0/month

n8n (free, self-hosted)

- Open source, 200+ integrations
- Self-host on a \$5/month VPS or run locally
- Most powerful free option by far

Make.com (free tier)

- 1,000 operations/month
- Visual workflow builder
- Good for simple automations

Zapier (free tier)

- 100 tasks/month
- 5 zaps (workflows)
- Most popular, most integrations

Tier 1: \$9-20/month

Make.com (\$9/month)

- 10,000 operations/month
- Covers most solopreneur needs
- Better value than Zapier for complex workflows

OR n8n Cloud (\$20/month) if you don't want to self-host

Tier 2: \$29-50/month

Make.com (\$16-29/month) for more operations

OR Zapier (\$20-49/month) if your tools only integrate with Zapier

+ n8n self-hosted for custom automations that need code

Tier 3: \$50-100/month

Make.com + n8n + custom Python scripts

At this level, you're building custom automation pipelines. The tools connect standard apps. Python handles everything custom.

The recommended stacks

The \$0 stack (everything free)

Category	Tool	Cost
AI writing	ChatGPT free + Claude free	\$0
Images	Canva free + Ideogram free	\$0
Video	CapCut free	\$0
Voice	Your phone's recorder	\$0
Email	Beehiiv free	\$0
Outreach	Manual Gmail	\$0
Scheduling	Buffer free	\$0
Website	Carrd free or Vercel free	\$0
Payments	Stripe (per transaction)	\$0
Analytics	GA4 + Search Console	\$0
Design	Canva free	\$0
Automation	Make.com free	\$0
Total		\$0/month

You can run a real business on \$0/month in tools. It's slower, it has limits, but it works. Start here if you have no revenue.

The \$47 stack (most popular)

Category	Tool	Cost
AI writing	Claude Pro	\$20
Images	Canva Pro	\$13
Video	CapCut free	\$0
Voice	ElevenLabs Starter	\$5
Email	Beehiiv free	\$0
Outreach	Apollo free + manual	\$0
Scheduling	Buffer free	\$0
Website	Vercel free	\$0
Payments	Stripe	\$0
Analytics	GA4 free	\$0
Design	Canva Pro (included above)	\$0
Automation	Make.com (\$9)	\$9
Total		\$47/month

This stack handles everything from content creation to automation for under \$50/month.

The \$150 stack (serious builder)

Category	Tool	Cost
AI writing	Claude Pro + ChatGPT Plus	\$40
Images	Leonardo.ai	\$12
Video	HeyGen	\$24
Voice	ElevenLabs Creator	\$22
Email	Beehiiv free	\$0
Outreach	Instantly.ai	\$37
Scheduling	Publer	\$12
Website	Vercel free	\$0
Payments	Stripe + Whop	\$0
Analytics	GA4 + Hotjar free	\$0
Design	Canva Pro	\$13
Automation	Make.com	\$9
Total		\$169/month

This is the stack that scales. Everything you need to produce content, send outreach, and build products at volume.

When to upgrade (decision framework)

Don't upgrade because a tool is "better." Upgrade because the current tool is costing you time or revenue.

Upgrade when:

- You hit the free tier limit more than 3 times per week

- A task takes 2x longer because of tool limitations
- You're losing money by not having a feature (e.g., no email warmup = spam folder)
- The upgrade pays for itself within 30 days (calculate: time saved x your hourly rate)

Don't upgrade when:

- You're not using the current tool to its full potential
- You're upgrading because someone recommended it on Twitter
- The free tier handles your current volume
- You're spending money before making money

The upgrade test

Before buying any tool, answer these 3 questions:

1. What specific problem does this solve that my current setup doesn't?
2. How many hours per week will this save me?
3. Will this directly lead to more revenue within 30 days?

If you can't answer all 3 specifically, you don't need the upgrade yet.

Tools I've tested and don't recommend (save your money)

Tool	Why not	Use instead
Jasper (\$49/month)	Too expensive for what it does. C..	Claude Pro (\$20)
Hootsuite (\$99/month)	Overpriced for solopreneurs. Ente..	Publer (\$12)
Mailchimp (\$13+/month)	Worse free tier than Beehiiv. Con..	Beehiiv (free)
Canva for Teams (\$30/month)	You're one person. Pro is enough.	Canva Pro (\$13)
Notion AI (\$10/month add-on)	Redundant if you have ChatGPT/Cla..	Claude Pro (\$20)
Grammarly Pro (\$12/month)	AI writing tools handle grammar a..	Built into ChatGPT/Claude
Later (\$25/month)	Publer and Buffer do the same for..	Buffer (\$0-6/channel)

Quick reference: Tool comparison tables

AI writing: Head to head

Feature	ChatGPT Plus	Claude Pro	Gemini Advanced
Price	\$20/mo	\$20/mo	\$20/mo
Long-form quality	Good	Best	Good
Short-form speed	Best	Good	Good
Image generation	Yes (DALL-E)	No	Yes (Imagen)
Code generation	Good	Best	Good
Instruction following	Good	Best	Moderate

File upload	Yes	Yes	Yes
Pick if	All-rounder	Long content/code	Research + images

Video tools: Head to head

Feature	HeyGen	D-ID	CapCut
Price	\$24/mo	\$6/mo	Free
AI avatars	Yes (best)	Yes (basic)	No
Video editing	Basic	No	Full
Auto captions	No	No	Yes
Templates	Limited	Limited	Extensive
Pick if	UGC/talking head	Budget UGC	Editing/captions

Email: Head to head

Feature	Beehiiv	Substack	ConvertKit
Price	Free-\$99	Free (10% on paid)	\$9-25/mo
Free tier	2,500 subs	Unlimited	1,000 subs
Monetization	Ads + paid subs	Paid subs	Paid subs + tips
Discovery	Yes (network)	Yes (network)	No
Automations	Good	Basic	Best
Pick if	Monetization focus	Writing focus	Complex funnels

Your action plan

1. Identify your tier based on current monthly revenue
2. Audit your current tools -- are you paying for things you don't use?
3. Fill gaps from the recommended stack for your tier
4. Set a calendar reminder to re-evaluate tools every quarter
5. Rule of thumb: If a free tool does 80% of what the paid one does, use the free one until you need the other 20%

The best tool stack is the one you actually use. Don't optimize your stack. Optimize your output.

Disclaimer: Results not typical. Individual results vary based on effort, market conditions, and other factors.